

who saved a cumulative \$225,000, who gave permission to five more friends, you would have a ripple effect that led to \$1.12 million that stayed in the hands of 125 of your friends and out of the hands of shareholder-friendly, impulse marketing savvy, big businesses. Just by implementing the information in this book to help you avoid impulse buying a handful of items at the grocery store, some clothes from Amazon, and a few well-intentioned but unused planners, you have the potential to put millions of dollars back in the hands of those who will do the most good with it. Because we know who will not do the most good with it.

After nonfinancial corporate profits reached an all-time high of \$2.09 trillion<sup>1</sup> in 2022, economist Paul Donovan published a note on “profit margin-led inflation,”<sup>2</sup> describing how companies, particularly retailers of food and consumer goods, convinced people that they needed to raise prices because of inflation and labor shortages when they actually didn’t, and no one questioned it. The perfect storm allowed businesses to raise prices more than what was needed with no loss in consumption, leading to soaring profit margins. And no one would admit that those companies were driving more of the inflation than they were responding to.

But this perfect storm was driven by our consumption. Spending in 2023 increased even after adjusting for inflation.<sup>3</sup> And this doesn’t take into consideration the long-term costs associated with our purchases.

Global consumption of fast fashion has increased by 400 percent<sup>4</sup> in the last twenty years and 85 percent of textiles end up in landfills. Every year 30 to 40 percent of all food produced for human consumption in America ends up in landfills.<sup>5</sup> That’s more than one hundred billion pounds, worth more than \$400 billion. Grocery stores are responsible for only \$5.6 billion of that. The average American consumer is responsible for most, spending an estimated \$1,300 per year<sup>6</sup> on food that ends up being thrown away. This doesn’t just impact our grocery bill directly, it also increases our taxes and utility bills. A total of 10 percent of the US energy budget is spent transporting food, and our taxes subsidize a large portion of US food production, of which a third is wasted. This waste leads to the need for more landfills, which can cost cities up to \$43.5 million a year in dumping fees. A leading reason why the garbage industry has been more profitable than the stock market<sup>7</sup> since 2015.

We’re also incentivizing businesses to look the other way when faced with human rights violations in manufacturing. They lower their responsible